

Is Malta first in the EU for reported pollution?

Testing a media claim about Malta's share of people reporting pollution against Eurostat data

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“35% of people in Malta reported exposure to pollution in 2023 — the highest share in the EU.”

Amphora Media, 2026 Election Guidebook: The Environment, 12 May 2026.
Citing Eurostat (series not named).

VERDICT: SUPPORTED

Accurate; it measures reported problems, not measured exposure

TL;DR

Amphora Media’s *2026 Election Guidebook: The Environment* (12 May 2026) says: **“35% of people in Malta reported exposure to pollution in 2023 — the highest share in the EU.”** In the body it adds that this is “nearly three times the EU average of 12%”. Amphora does not name its source. We tested both statements against Eurostat’s EU-SILC survey indicator on pollution, grime and other environmental problems.

- 1

The numbers are right. Eurostat gives 34.7% for Malta and 12.2% for the EU-27 in 2023. Rounded, that is 35% and 12%; the ratio is 2.8.
- 2

Malta is first in the EU, by a wide margin. Greece is second at 20.5%. Malta has been first in every survey year with data since 2005 (17 of 17).
- 3

It measures what people report, not what is measured in the air. The survey asks whether the household has a problem with pollution, grime or other environmental problems in its area. Amphora’s body text says this (“pollution, grime, and other environmental problems”); the intro line says “exposure to pollution”, which reads as a stronger, measured claim.
- 4

Not a recent deterioration. The share peaked at 41.4% in 2011 and reached a low of 26.5% in 2017; 2023 is 8 points above that low.
- 5

Verdict: supported (high confidence). The statistic, the rank and the comparison are accurate. The caveat is the label: this is perceived, self-reported pollution.

THIS CLAIM

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

34.7%

Malta, 2023: reporting pollution, grime or other environmental problems

12.2%

EU-27 average, 2023

1st

Malta’s rank among 27 Member States; Greece second at 20.5%

17 of 17

Survey years since 2005 with Malta ranked first

WHAT WOULD MOVE THE VERDICT UP

A correction of the Eurostat figures (revised data), or evidence that the Maltese result reflects a question or sampling difference rather than the experience of residents.

WHAT WOULD MOVE IT DOWN

Measured exposure data (EEA air-quality and noise maps) showing Malta’s exposure is not elevated, which would turn this into a perception-only statistic that the intro line overstates.

IN THIS REPORT

- 1 The claim and what we could verify
- 2 Method
- 3 What the indicator measures
- 4 What the data show

- 5 Where the evidence points different ways
- 6 Testing the claim
- 7 Verdict and requests for evidence
- 8 Limitations

1 The claim and what we could verify

The claim is Amphora Media’s own text, read in full on 5 October 2026 [1]. Amphora is a news outlet; we assess its wording, not any authority’s. It attributes the figure to “the report” without naming it, so we identified the Eurostat series that reproduces it [2].

What Amphora says	Where	Access
“35% of people in Malta reported exposure to pollution in 2023 — the highest share in the EU.”	Introduction [1]	Read in full
“In 2023, more than a third of people (35%) in Malta reported exposure to pollution, grime, and other environmental problems. This is the highest share in the EU and nearly three times the EU average of 12%.”	Section “Is Malta becoming cleaner?” [1]	Read in full
“According to the report, high-earning households were more affected than low-earning ones.”	Same section [1]	Read in full; source report not named

SCOPE NOTE

This check tests the figures and the wording “reported exposure to pollution”. It does not assess Malta’s actual air or environmental quality, which is covered by other checks. Amphora’s guidebook contains other statements that we did not test here.

2 Method

Question. Are the 35%, the “highest in the EU” ranking and the comparison with a 12% EU average accurate, and does “reported exposure to pollution” describe what was measured?

Evidence. This claim is statistical. We downloaded Eurostat’s *ilc_mddw02* (updated 13 August 2026) through the dissemination API on 5 October 2026 [2], kept all Member States and years, and recomputed rank, ratios and trend with *tools/cc-037-report/calc.py* from *data/cc-037/*. Peer-reviewed literature was searched (Crossref, OpenAlex) for work comparing self-reported pollution with measurements.

Grades. Official statistics are grade C under our scale. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the indicator measures

The indicator comes from the EU Statistics on Income and Living Conditions (EU-SILC), a household survey run by national statistics offices. Respondents say whether their dwelling or its surroundings have a problem with “pollution, grime or other environmental problems”. The indicator is the percentage answering yes [2]. It records perceived problems, which depend on what people notice and tolerate as well as on the environment.

Self-reports and measurement overlap but do not coincide. In one Spanish cohort of 504 pregnant women, self-reported air-pollution annoyance was associated with modelled NO₂ and VOC levels, but category-by-category agreement was low to moderate (11–72%) [3]. That is a conference abstract from another country and is context only. It supports the caution in the verdict, not the numbers.

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What the data show

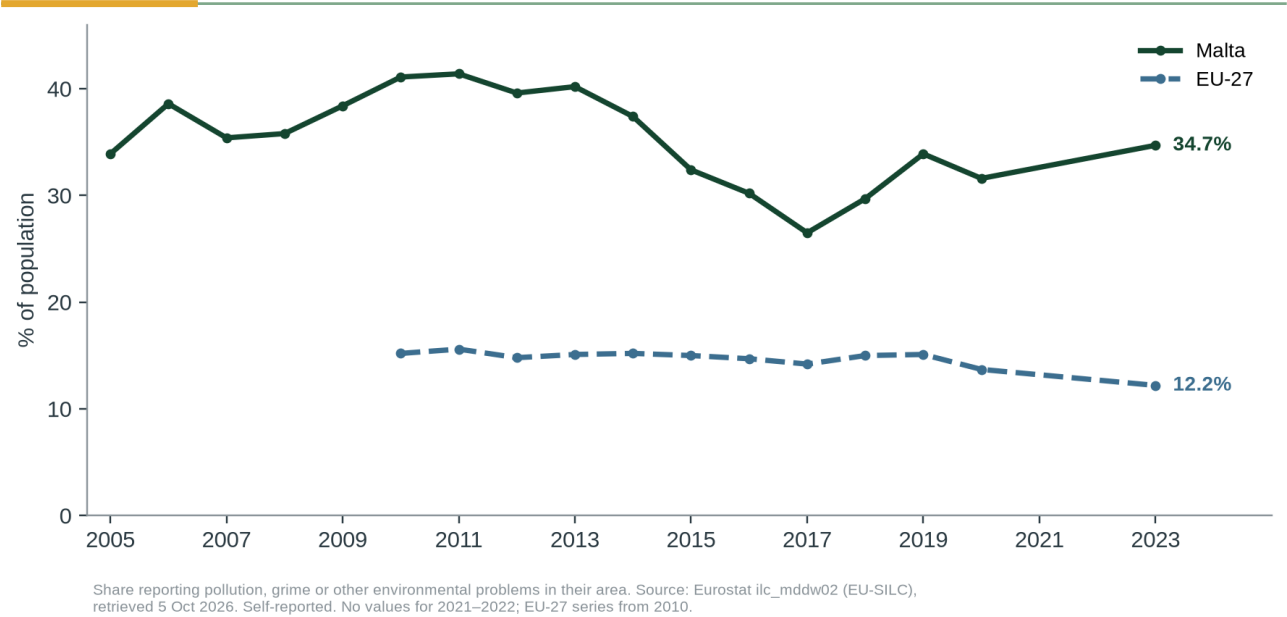


Figure 1. Population reporting pollution, grime or other environmental problems, Malta and EU-27. Malta's series peaked at 41.4% in 2011, fell to 26.5% in 2017 and has risen since.

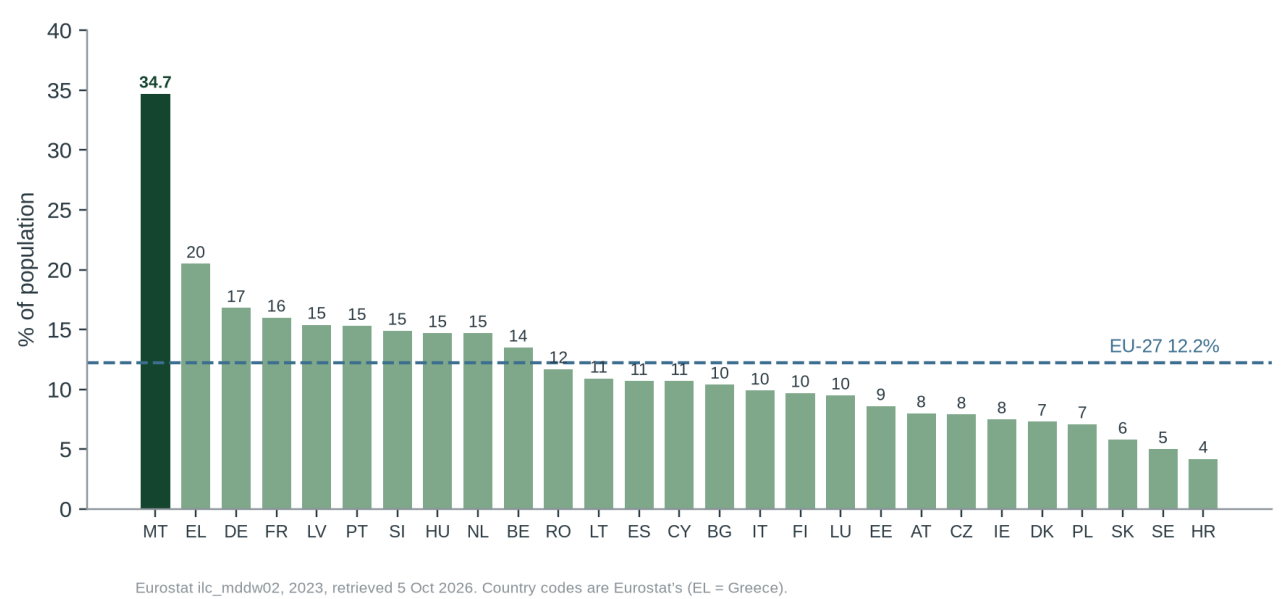


Figure 2. The same indicator for all 27 Member States, 2023. Malta ranks first.

Indicator	Malta	EU / comparison	Source	Grade
Reporting pollution, grime or other problems, 2023	34.7%	12.2% (EU-27)	Eurostat [2]	C
Ratio to EU-27 average, 2023	2.84×	–	calculated	C
Rank among 27 Member States, 2023	1st	next: Greece 20.5%	calculated	C
Years ranked first, 2005–2023	17 of 17	–	calculated	C
Above / below 60% of median income, 2023	35.6% / 30.1%	11.8% / 14.0% (EU-27)	Eurostat [2]	C

All values in data/cc-037/checks.csv. No data exist for 2021 and 2022. Amphora’s statement that higher earners were more affected agrees with the income split.

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Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Is “reported exposure to pollution” an accurate description?		ACCURATE IN THE BODY, LOOSER IN THE INTRO
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM’S IMPRESSION The body text uses the survey’s wording: “pollution, grime, and other environmental problems”. “Reported” makes clear that this is what people said.	EVIDENCE AGAINST The intro line shortens this to “exposure to pollution”. A reader could take that as measured exposure, which the survey does not provide, and “grime” covers dirt that is not pollution in the regulatory sense.	
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: the statistic is accurate; the shorthand slightly widens its meaning.		

Q2 Does the ranking reflect real conditions or a survey effect?		UNCERTAIN; RANKING IS ROBUST
EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM’S IMPRESSION Malta has led the EU for 17 survey years with a gap of 14 points in 2023, so a single year’s sampling noise does not explain it. Malta’s density and traffic are consistent with high reporting.	EVIDENCE AGAINST Perception varies with expectations, and national survey practice differs. We found no study that separates these for Malta.	
WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE For this claim: the rank is accurate as a statement about reports. Causes are outside this check.		

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Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. 35% of people in Malta reported pollution in 2023	Eurostat: 34.7% [2].	ACCURATE
B. The highest share in the EU	First of 27; Greece second at 20.5%; first in all 17 years with data [2].	ACCURATE
C. Nearly three times the EU average of 12%	12.2% EU-27; ratio 2.84 (2.9 on the rounded figures) [2].	ACCURATE
D. “Exposure to pollution” (intro wording)	The survey records perceived problems, not measured exposure [2, 3].	LOOSE WORDING
E. High earners more affected than low earners	35.6% above vs 30.1% below 60% of median income [2].	ACCURATE

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Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

SUPPORTED

The figures, rank and comparison are accurate; they describe reported problems, not measured exposure. Confidence: high.

Why. (1) The 35%, the first place in the EU and the comparison with the EU average all reproduce from Eurostat's own data. (2) The result is stable across 17 survey years. (3) The only caveat is that the indicator is self-reported; Amphora's body text says "reported", and our scale treats a caveat of that size as not altering the substance of a statement.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say that Malta's measured pollution is the highest in the EU, that any particular source is to blame, or that any authority has failed. It addresses only whether Amphora's statement is accurate.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ The source Amphora refers to as "the report" for the 35% and the income split (not named in the guidebook).
- ☐ Measured exposure data (EEA air quality, noise maps) that could be set beside this perception indicator in a future check.

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Limitations

- The indicator is self-reported and cannot be read as measured exposure.
- We did not compare it with measured concentrations in Malta; no such comparison was part of the claim.
- No data exist for 2021–2022; 2023 is the latest year.
- We could not identify the report Amphora cites; the match to Eurostat *ilc_mddw02* is ours, through the figures (35%, 12%, income split).
- The Aguilera abstract [3] is a conference abstract from Spain; it was read as an abstract only and is context.

References

- [1] Amphora Media (12 May 2026). 2026 Election Guidebook: The Environment. (Read in full, 5 Oct 2026.) <https://www.amphora.media/2026/05/2026-election-guidebook-the-environment>
- [2] Eurostat. *ilc_mddw02* Pollution, grime or other environmental problems (EU-SILC); updated 13 Aug 2026, retrieved 5 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/ilc_mddw02/default/table
- [3] Aguilera I., Sunyer J., Fernández-Patier R., Jacquemin B., Aguirre A., Bomboi T. (2007). Self-reported traffic, air pollution annoyance, and GIS-modeled exposure to air pollutants in pregnant women. *Epidemiology* 18:S43. doi:10.1097/01.ede.0000276553.96485.21. (Conference abstract read.) <https://doi.org/10.1097/01.ede.0000276553.96485.21>
- [4] Miżien. Data and calculations: [data/cc-037/](#); [tools/cc-037-report/calc.py](#).

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** before wider circulation and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	5 Oct 2026	First issue. No right of reply needed for a Supported verdict.